



THE INADEQUACY OF THE STAFF IS WORSENERD BY OUTDATED PRACTICES OF RECORD-KEEPING. IT BECOMES DIFFICULT TO MONITOR TEMPLE-RELATED DEVELOPMENTS.



(EXTREME LEFT) THE TIRUMALA TEMPLE; (TOP) ARRESTED PRIEST DIKSHITULLU AND (LEFT) ORNAMENTS AT THE TIRUMALA TEMPLE

plenty of work, including monitoring the *hundi* collections, gold and silver offerings and protecting the existing jewellery, apart from selling tickets. The inadequacy of staff is worsened by outdated practices of record-keeping that makes it difficult to monitor temple-related developments. Periodic physical verification of jewellery, though mandatory, is not done "due to pressure of work".

Consequently, the scope for acts of wrong-doing and siphoning away of devotees' offerings is high. At Tiruchanur, the second main temple managed by the TTD, *darshan* tickets were found to have been recycled as there was no inspection. A few years ago, 200 five-gm gold coins were stolen,

and 19 officials and employees were suspended thereafter.

The startling discovery of pawning jewellery has also spawned allegations, including one that some of the original ornaments have been replaced with fakes. But with the high court setting a November 1 deadline for the TTD to furnish details, the temple managers have no option but to disclose it in their inventory. Consequently, the information on all property, including jewellery, will be put up on a portal which will be launched on October 2. Such transparency can be the first step in improving management and accountability in the administration of the 36,000-odd temples in the state.

While the offenders have to be punished, the penury of the priests cannot be glossed over. Those working in the TTD-run temples are paid paltry salaries and do not enjoy benefits extended to employees. Just two years ago, it was raised from the measly Rs 1,200 to Rs 7,500 a month. Their condition is worse at other temples. The Endowments Department has introduced a scheme wherein Rs 2,500 is paid to each temple—Rs 1,500 as the *purohit's* salary and Rs 1,000 for other expenses. But this covers only 3,400 temples in the state.

The cash-strapped state has always relied on the TTD for generous contributions to the Common Good Fund for renovation of these temples. But this has been reduced to a trickle. The TTD gave just Rs 3 crore during the last financial year. "We need at least Rs 82 crore for renovation work and we are waiting for TTD's contribution," says Endowments Minister Gade Venkata Reddy. Meanwhile, the lax temple administration has come handy for rival political parties to allege that there are gross acts of misdemeanor in the TTD, poor protection and apathetic appraisal of the jewels and other ornaments, resulting in their devaluation. There is also a demand for reconstituting the TTD Board as many think it has become a political asylum—an allusion to its chairman D.K. Adikesavulu Naidu who was rewarded with this plum post after he switched loyalties from the TDP to the Congress. Others contend that the Sri Venkateswara Bhakti Channel, the broadcasting arm of the TTD, is a white elephant and needs to be revamped.

For its part, the state is to launch a Dharmika Parishad, a collegium of Hindu Mutt heads, to provide the much-needed guidance on temple administration. But that may not be enough. It is also to consider appointing gemology experts to assess the value of the jewellery, diamonds and other precious stones in the safe keeping of the TTD. Unless the Government stands firm and ensure that its proposals are implemented, the latest theft at the TTD may yet again prove that faith can never overcome greed. ■